THE DEATH

The sad death of the locomotive is referred in passing while discussing the calculation of rates and quantity of earth ferried in the fourth method of working.

> On the fourth item, our experience in rates of earth as obtained by the use of a locomotive was too short to admit of our arriving at any satisfactory conclusions, an accident having placed the machine hors de combat a few months after it had been on the works. The water had been drawn off and it was supposed that the fire had been entirely extinguished. A storm with wind, however, brought the fire and fuel which were in the furnace into action, destroyed the casing, together with a number of the tubes, and placed the locomotive completely out of use. [25]

It is not clear if the locomotive was ever revived for the runs, but it most probably ended up as a stationary engine along the canal works. But such raw experiments make for important documentation of how they tried to utilize steam power for locomotion. It also gives us an insight into how such trials gave a first-hand experience to the Indians of the generation at various levels and in various parts of the subcontinent. Every new experiment led to improvization and added finesse. The era of the Indian Railways had begun!

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[10] Simon Darwill, 'India's First Railways,' Dec 2011, http://www.irfca.org/docs/history/india-first-railways.html

[11] The trials were documented in January 1839 by Captain John Thomas Smith in *Reports, Correspondence and Original Papers on Various Professional Subjects Connected with the Duties of Corps of Engineers of Madras Presidency—vol.1*

[12] Coleroon is today's Kollidam river that is the northern distributary of the Kaveri river and it flows through the delta of Thanjavur.

[13] Trichinopoly covers the present-day districts of Tiruchirappalli, Karur, Ariyalur and Perambalur in the Indian state of Tamil Nadu.

[14] J.T. Smith, 'Notes of some experiments made by A.Cotton, upon Mr Avery's steam engine,' *Reports, Correspondence and Original Papers on Various Professional Subjects Connected with the Duties of Corps of Engineers of Madras Presidency—vol.1* , pp.95–100

[15] Smith, 'Steam Engine,' 95–100

[16] Smith, 'Steam Engine,' 95–100

[17] The arms mean the piston rods here.

[18] This is an engineering colloquial of a gradient or a slope.